HOW TO SELL A JOB



STEP 1

The West Bengal School Service Commission conducts the state-level selection test in 2016 to recruit teachers for Classes IX to XII. Results are out in 2017 but without a merit list. Candidates could only check scores online. So they do not know their ranks, and are uncertain if they made the cut. As some get interview calls, others grow desperate.



STEP 2

Word spreads that the jobs are being 'sold'. Agents allegedly identify candidates willing to pay. There are believed to be various price tags—Rs 8-10 lakh for teachers in Class IX-X, Rs 10-15 lakh for Class XI-XII and Rs 20 lakh for candidates from other states, those who did not have BEd degrees or who did not even appear for the test.



STEP 3

Based on payments, agents allegedly prepared lists of candidates to be recommended. Unsuccessful candidates got answer scripts for revaluation through RTIs. OMR sheets got corrected with higher marks. Appointment letters are given to these candidates, bypassing genuine ones.

Illustrations by RAJ VERMA

the illegal recommendations were the activities of the "five-member so-called supervisory committee" appointed by Partha Chatterjee.

Mamata had met the protesting candidates in March 2019 and thereafter asked Chatterjee to form a panel to look into the complaints. This was duly formed under a government order, although technically such an empowered panel on recruitments could not have been constituted without first amending the School Service Commission Act, 1997. But even more eyebrow-raising was its composition. It seemed like a veritable Chatterjee club: Sinha; Alok Sarkar, deputy director of education; Sukanta Acharjee, private secretary to Chatterjee; P.K. Bandyopadhyay, OSD to Chatterjee; and T. Panja, law officer.

Even if irregular, its formation was ostensibly well-intentioned: it was supposed to smooth out the wrinkles in the recruitment process. Instead, it started recommending newer appointments. One of their recommendations was Ankita Adhikari, daughter of Paresh Chandra Adhikari, the current minister of state for education. On May 20, on finding that she had landed a job despite being neither empanelled nor wait-listed, Justice Ganguly terminated her employment and directed her to return the salary earned. The CBI has booked both Adhikari and his daughter. Though it hasn't directly named Chatterjee as an accused in its FIR filed on May 20, his name has been dragged into the alleged scam for approving the formation of the supervisory committee. Justice Ganguly has dubbed Sinha, the panel's head, the "main culprit".

THE MODUS OPERANDI

According to many candidates, the operation was carried out by a well-oiled nexus. Agents, working allegedly for the minister and his aides, hung around cyber cafes, photocopy shops and tea stalls to target gullible, desperate candidates willing to pay for a job. The rate varied from Rs 8 lakh to Rs 20 lakh. In a state where nearly 200,000 government job vacancies were filled up in the past decade with people hired on contract or reduced salaries, advertisements for teachers' posts with monthly salaries of Rs 45,000 (graduates) and Rs 70,000 (PG candidates) and Rs 30,000-Rs 45,000 for non-teaching staff expectedly